

Uepaki — Seller Acquisition Red Team Audit

Independent review of the acquisition system, database selections, messages and conversion design

9 October 2026 · Internal · For Sahil Mittal · Not public

Verdict

AMBER — execution possible, but specific blockers must be resolved first.

A one-week **journey test** with 5–10 friendly professionals (Wave –1) may start as soon as the Refer & Earn redirect is removed. **Do not begin cold outreach (Wave 0)** until these gates are closed:

Gate	Blocker
G1	Founder-approved founding wording for 1:1 use (FP-OUT)
G2	The seller journey proven end to end in production by the Wave –1 test
G3	Interim information note approved; the terms a seller accepts at registration today are known and acceptable
G4	A policy for sellers without a verified GSTIN (orders are blocked in code)
G6	Sign-up redirect to Refer & Earn removed
G7	A credible, approved page/link and a professional sender identity

Before Wave 1, also close:

Gate	Blocker
G5	U-1 — can free sellers withdraw earnings?
G8	Legal view on the outreach method
G9	Legacy-account handling
G10	Founding qualifying rule
G11	Service/booking features at launch

The full gate list, with live status and an automatic verdict, is in the Command Center (BLOCKERS).

Why not GREEN. The strategy is sound. The weakest links are the product and terms the professional meets *after* saying yes, and a selection model that favoured the professionals who need Uepaki least.

Why not RED. Every blocker is a decision or a fix within the founder's control, and none requires new research or spend.

1. Method

I reviewed every previous deliverable without assuming it was correct:

- Operating System;
- Segmentation and the First 25/100/300 lists;
- Outreach Message Engine (346 messages);
- Conversion, Objection, Founding, Onboarding, Referral, KPI and “who has joined” documents.

I re-ran analyses on 01_MASTER_V2 and checked each claim against the founder records (Brief Rev 07, S07, the records of 6 October 2026), the evidence records (EV-01, EV-02, the code handoff, register 18) and Brand Doctrine.

The founder's answer of 9 October on legacy sellers is incorporated: they registered 3–5 years ago, none is active, and they are not considered reliable.

Severity scale:

Severity	Meaning
Critical	Would make outreach fail, mislead, or breach a decision
High	Materially lowers conversion or creates risk
Medium	Inefficiency or inconsistency
Low	Polish

2. Strategy findings

#	Finding	Evidence	Severity	Fix
S1	The plan recruits into a journey nobody has tested end to end. Registration needs a Razorpay ₹1 + GST payment. Product creation needs KYC and an approved store. <code>create_listing</code> is subscription-gated contrary to policy. Withdrawing earnings is premium. The app path differs from the web path	EV-01; code handoff rows 1, 13; SUB-06	Critical	Wave -1 journey test with friendly professionals before any cold contact (G2)
S2	Verified-GSTIN requirement on orders conflicts with the target profile. The OS deliberately prioritises independents, the group least likely to be GST-registered	EV-01 (c)	Critical	Founder + CA policy (G4). Ask about GST status before registration. No tax advice
S3	Nothing approved to send when a professional says "send details". Seller Policy v1.4 is an internal draft; founding terms are open	Seller Policy v1.4 review package; S07	Critical	Approve the interim information note; establish which terms registration currently binds (G3)
S4	No credibility surface. The site isn't live for customers and the landing-page action is blocked (LP-1). An unknown sender asking busy professionals to register for an unlaunched marketplace, with nothing to check, reads as a scam	LP-1; Objection R14 relies on "[APPROVED LINK]"	Critical	One approved page (what Uepaki is, its stage, the founder's name), a domain email with SPF/DKIM/DMARC, and a Uepaki Instagram with real content before DMs (G7, G13)
S5	The "ideal initial community" target (120–180 activated at launch) is not supported by the capacity math. Using the system's own test rates (reply 10–25% × interest 30–50% × interested → activated 25–40%), cold outreach yields roughly 0.75–5% contacted → activated: about 2–15 activated per 300 contacts. That is arithmetic on test thresholds, not a forecast	OS §11 vs KPI framework	High	Replace with staged goals. Pods first; count what's real. Supplement with inbound and peer introductions. Never back-fill with legacy accounts
S6	The OS capacity example used a 20% end-to-end rate. Implausible for cold outreach to busy professionals before launch, with no social proof	OS §13	Medium	Use 1–5% for planning; treat anything above as upside
S7	Wedding-season collision. Waves 1–3 (November–January) fall in peak wedding season. Beauty, Lens and emcees make up half of v1's First 300	Assumption A3; v1 composition	High	Product-capable categories lead November–December. Wedding-service outreach limited to anchors, with bulk recruitment after the season
S8	Ten cities in 12 weeks with a small team cannot form real pods. It spreads thin exactly where "who has joined?" needs density	v1 First 300: 10 cities	High	Four anchor cities through launch. Others only via inbound or category-gap fill
S9	Founder bottleneck. The founder signs anchors, tier C notes, calls, weekly activation sign-off, every L2 escalation, all public numbers, monthly sessions per category and every founding welcome, on top of the Rev 07 decision queue	OS §14; Founding §8	High	Founder time goes to decisions, anchors and Wave -1. Team-signed notes for tier A/B. One monthly founding session, not six
S10	Document sprawl. Over 30 files across four packs; a small team cannot operate from them	Repository	Medium	One Master Launch Playbook and one Command Center are operative. Everything else is reference

#	Finding	Evidence	Severity	Fix
S11	The pilot A/B test at n≈12 per arm cannot detect anything , as the framework itself admits	Experimentation §2	Medium	Use one message in Wave 0. Treat the pilot as a journey and objection test. Run A/B tests from Wave 1
S12	Legacy accounts unaddressed. Earlier work ignored the existing (dormant) seller base. Risks: counted as “joined”; consuming “first 500” seats; dormant profiles visible to customers at launch	Library references to real sellers; founder, 9 Oct	High	G9: exclude from counts; activation-based FP-QUAL; decide on hiding dormant profiles; legal terms-migration notice only
S13	Stacked incentives are an open-ended liability , even though acquisition never leads with discounts. Early-bird 70% (first period), founding lifetime –2 points, a possible 2% offer, with stacking allowed in direction	Answers #6, #7; S07	Medium	Before publishing terms: a CA model of stacked economics per category slab. Lead with the proposition, never the discount
S14	Inconsistent guidance on the paid-placement policy. The outreach DO NOT SAY list bans visibility statements; the objection playbook lets staff state the decided policy when asked. Staff will be confused	DO NOT SAY vs Objection #10	Medium	The rule: state the exact policy sentence only in reply to a direct question. Not in cold messages until the founder decides B1-OUT (G14). Never “cannot be bought” or mechanics
S15	Four-message sequences contradict the OS three-touch rule. The message library builds M1–M4; the OS says three touches	Message library vs OS §8	Low	Cold sequence = M1 → M2 → M4. M3 only on interest

What’s sound and should be kept:

- contactability separated from consent, with no cold WhatsApp;
- fame excluded from scoring; tier D/E barred from P0;
- ecosystem pods as the “who has joined?” answer;
- activation as the north star;
- truthful founding positioning;
- a suppression list;
- small-cell, gated waves.

3. Database findings

#	Finding	Evidence	Severity	Fix
D1	v1 selection favoured the professionals who need Uepaki least. ARS weights commercial activity and marketplace affinity heavily, so it selects saturated, stockist-backed labels. All 5 Fashion picks in the First 25 are stockist-listed, and 4 have 250+ product catalogues. Two Space picks are established multi-store brands (one is noted by research as “multi-city stores; mid-tier brand rather than independent studio”)	Red-team flags on v1 First 25	High	v2 scoring: penalise stockist + large catalogue; exclude established/multi-store brands from early waves; bonus for under-discovered
D2	Emerging professionals were under-represented , contrary to the OS’s own recommendation (tier A 20–30%). v1: tier A = 2/25 (8%), 7/100 (7%), 45/300 (15%), while the contact-ready pool is 24% tier A (373/1,538)	v1 lists	High	v2: tier A floor of 20% per category quota. Result: 13/25, 39/100, 84/300
D3	“Under-discovered” professionals were ignored. The DB’s platform-saturation signal (233 contact-ready records marked under-represented or under-discovered) is the closest match to Uepaki’s purpose, but wasn’t used. v1 First 25 had 1	Platform Saturation Signal	Medium	v2 bonus; under-discovered = 8/25 and 56/300
D4	Over half of v1’s First 300 are service professionals (157) , whose	v1 composition	High	v2: service categories 40%. Product-capable categories lead

#	Finding	Evidence	Severity	Fix
	launch features (EV-09) and paid-plan status for bookings (23 C3 vs code: intracity bookings free; U-5 open) are unresolved			until G11 closes
D5	v1 included brand-demand-dependent creators (bloggers, content creators, production — 18 in the 300, 7 in the First 100), contrary to its own advice to hold them until after launch	v1 composition	Medium	v2 excludes these segments until Wave 4
D6	Fashion universe sourcing bias. Fashion records were largely harvested from stockist designer indexes (Aza 517, Pernia 121, Ogaan 88 associations), so the Fashion pool is structurally skewed to stockist-listed labels. Even v2's Fashion picks are stockist-listed	Platform associations	Medium	Accept for the pilot. Add Fashion prospects from non-stockist sources (craft clusters, D2C-only labels) through inbound and peer introductions, not paid research
D7	Beauty contactability. 960 of 1,169 Beauty records are reachable only via a wedding-platform phone line. Contact-ready Beauty = 118 nationally, about 59 in the four anchor cities. The v1 First 300 drew 70 of 118 (59% of the pool), scraping weaker records	Contact class	High	v2: Beauty 50, mostly anchor cities. Enrichment queue (250) before Wave 3
D8	Freemail “business” emails (102 of the v1 300) are often personal inboxes. Fine for 1:1 contact, but expect lower reply and higher sensitivity	Public Business Email	Low	Prefer a professional Instagram DM where both exist; never bulk
D9	Recency is fresh but will age. Routes were verified on 2026-10-08. By Wave 2 (about December) some will be stale	contact_verified_date	Medium	Re-verify the route on the day of sending (already in the checklist)
D10	Is the database good enough for paid outreach? No. It is fit for 1:1 manual outreach only . Uploading it to ad platforms (custom audiences) or to a bulk email or WhatsApp tool would use personal data without consent	Opt-in = 0	Critical (if attempted)	Never upload the database to any ad, bulk email or BSP tool
D11	Premium names are not over-represented. Tier D/E = 69, routed to P3; none in any list. Celebrity bias: not found	—	—	Keep
D12	City balance. Delhi NCR dominates (v2: 151/300) because supply is deepest there (495 contact-ready). This is supply, not demand	City matrix	Medium	Acceptable for the pilot. Watch the guardrail; re-weight when demand data exists

Golden 300 v2 versus v1

Measure	v1 First 300	v2 Golden 300
Tier A / B / C	45 / 173 / 82	84 / 176 / 40
Under-discovered	36	56
Stockist-listed with large catalogue	41	35
Established / multi-store brands	8	0
Service categories	157 (52%)	120 (40%)
Brand-demand creators	18	0
Cities	10	4 anchors (Delhi NCR 151, Mumbai 92, Bengaluru 30, Jaipur 27)
OS-P0 / mean ARS	271 / 75.7	237 / 76.2
Overlap with v1	—	158 of 300; 7 of the First 25

v2 is pre-filled in the Command Center. The v1 list workbooks remain as reference and should **not** be used to sequence outreach.

4. Message findings

#	Finding	Severity	Fix
M1	First messages are too long for cold contact. Email M1 runs ~1,050–1,250 characters (~180–210 words, five paragraphs); the IG DM M1 is ~480 characters. The long FD-06 sentence plus a long FP-OUT placeholder dominate	High	Rewritten M1s below: email ≤ 110 words, DM ≤ 300 characters
M2	The CTA asks too much of a stranger. “Would a 15-minute conversation be useful?” asks for a meeting before trust exists	High	Low-friction CTA: “Shall I send a one-page note? A one-word reply is enough.” The call is offered after a reply
M3	The reason to respond is weak. The messages say what Uepaki is but rarely why this person should care now. The truthful hooks are being among the first invited in their city, alongside complementary peers; set-up help; and (once G14 is decided) the decided paid-placement policy	High	Rewrites lead with the specific observation, then “a few [peers] in [city] before launch”
M4	Template sameness across 26 segments. Only the relevance line, question and value points vary; the skeleton is identical. Readers who compare notes (pods talk) will notice	Medium	The observation and the one segment line carry the specificity; keep everything else short
M5	“Personally inviting a first group ... invited at the same time” is true only if operations actually batch pods	Medium	Keep the wording only when the pod is being contacted that week; otherwise “a few [peers] in [city]”
M6	Unsupported claims: none found. The automated scan (about 25 patterns) and manual review found no promises of customers, ranking, free registration, fake numbers or competitor names	—	Keep
M7	“Who else joined?”, “Why join?” and existing-platform objections are handled truthfully and well. Legacy accounts must not be counted (G9)	—	Keep; add the legacy rule
M8	Spam signals. No exclamation marks or hype. But a new, empty Instagram account sending many DMs will hit message requests and platform limits	High	G7; cap at 15–20 new DMs per day per account (initial test threshold); no automation

Rewritten first messages (replace M1 in Waves 0–2)

Email M1 (all segments). Subject: [STUDIO/LABEL NAME] and Uepaki

Hello [NAME],

[ONE SPECIFIC, ACCURATE OBSERVATION ABOUT [RELEVANT WORK]] — one sentence.]

I'm [FOUNDER/TEAM NAME], [ROLE] at Uepaki. We're preparing to launch a marketplace in India where customers can buy products and connect with creative professionals for services, bookings and projects. Before launch, we're inviting a few [PEERS] in [CITY], and [STUDIO/LABEL NAME] is the kind of [PRACTICE/LABEL] we'd like to start with.

[FP-OUT SHORT]

Shall I send a one-page note on how it would work for [PROFESSION]s? A one-word reply is enough. If it's not relevant, just say so and I won't write again.

[FOUNDER/TEAM NAME]

Instagram DM M1.

Hello [NAME] — [ONE SPECIFIC DETAIL] in [RELEVANT WORK] caught my eye. I'm [NAME] from Uepaki, a marketplace launching in India for products and creative services. We're inviting a few [PROFESSION]s in [CITY] before launch. Can I send you a short note? No problem if not.

Follow-up (M2), both channels.

Hello [NAME], a quick follow-up. If useful, I can send a one-page note, or set up your profile with you later from the work you already have. Either way, no pressure. Just reply here.

Final note (M4): unchanged.

M3, the objection replies and the segment lines from the Message Engine remain valid.

5. Conversion findings

The highest-risk points, and the smallest changes with the largest expected effect:

Rank	Risk point	Smallest high-impact change
1	Activation → first order for sellers without a GSTIN	One founder + CA decision (G4); one readiness question (R2) asked before registration
2	Interest → information	Approve the one-page interim note once (G3). That single document unlocks every “send details”
3	Information → registration	Register together on a 15-minute call: payment step, form and readiness, in one sitting. Web path only until the app is aligned
4	Registration → approval	A 3-business-day admin turnaround target, measured in the Command Center
5	Approval → first listing	The onboarding lead drafts the profile and first listing from the professional's existing work for their approval. Category-correct listing type (products only in Fashion, Space, Digital)
6	Payout set-up	Founder decision U-1 (G5) before anyone on the free core is activated
7	Activation → launch (dead time)	One monthly honest update to activated professionals; one founding session per month

Everything else in the Conversion Playbook is sound. In particular, the definition of activation, the 48/72-hour sequence and the escalation path are correct.

6. Operations and measurement findings

#	Finding	Severity	Fix
O1	Trackers fragmented across five workbooks	High	The Command Center is the single tracker
O2	No capacity rule tied to onboarding	Medium	New first contacts per week ≤ (onboarding calls available per week ÷ observed interest rate). Until measured, ≤ 10 new contacts per person per day
O3	No campaign-level stop/scale automation	Medium	The Command Center's CAMPAIGN_DASHBOARD applies the stop/scale rules automatically
O4	Budget lines undefined	Medium	The BUDGET sheet with allowed/not-allowed classes (Master Playbook §9)
O5	Vanity KPIs	—	Not found. Activation and transaction are the reported measures

7. Summary of blockers

Gate	Blocker	Severity	Before
G1	FP-OUT wording	Critical	W0
G2	End-to-end journey proven (Wave -1)	Critical	W0
G3	Interim note approved; registration-time terms known	Critical	W0
G4	Policy for sellers without a verified GSTIN	Critical	W0
G5	U-1 withdraw for free sellers	Critical	W1
G6	Remove the Refer & Earn redirect	Critical	W-1
G7	Credible page/link + sender identity	Critical	W0
G8	Legal view on the outreach method	High	W1
G9	Legacy dormant accounts: exclude from counts and founding seats; hide dormant profiles at launch (decision); terms-migration notice	High	W0 / launch
G10	FP-QUAL	High	W1
G11	Service/booking features at launch; U-5	High	W1 (services)
G12	Consent register	Medium	W1
G13	Email authentication	Medium	W0
G14	Policy sentence in outreach (B1-OUT)	Medium	optional

Final verdict: AMBER. Start the Wave -1 journey test once G6 is closed. Start Wave 0 cold outreach only when G1–G4, G7 and G13 are closed (G6 is already closed by then, since it gates Wave -1).